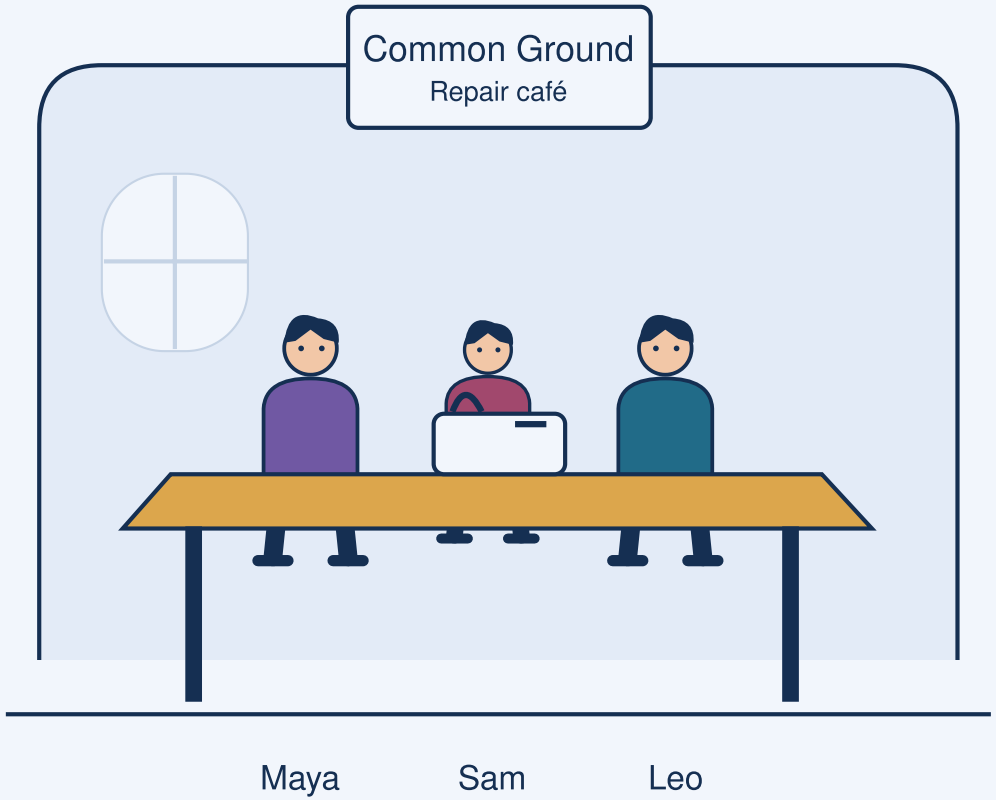
Chapter 10 · Story

A crash. A full room. A moment of hesitation.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



Who will do something? · c10s01

A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Why could concerned bystanders hesitate?

A Concern disappears when groups become large.

B People may be uncertain and assume someone else will act.

C Hesitation proves nobody cares.

Suggested answer: B. Ambiguity and divided responsibility can both contribute.

Helping has several decision points.

- Notice and interpret the need.
- Accept responsibility; identify a safe action.
- Act with available skills and support.



Helping involves noticing, interpreting, responsibility, and safe action.

Make constructive action easier.

- Aggression: behavior intended to harm.
- De-escalation: lower threat and preserve safety.
- Cooperation: align goals, roles, and feedback.



Helping involves noticing, interpreting, responsibility, and safe action.

What can we really conclude?

Laboratory aggression measures are imperfect indicators of serious violence. Bystander findings also vary with danger, relationships, and available support. A slogan about crowds can hide those differences. For a real emergency, follow local guidance and your training. A social psychology explanation does not replace first-aid instruction. Evaluate a practical change by whether appropriate, safe help becomes more available. Concern alone does not establish that a response plan works.



Conceptual illustration; no research data are plotted.

Try the idea somewhere new.

Which preparation makes future help more likely?

A Tell everyone to be more caring.

B Assume the most senior person handles all incidents.

C Agree on response roles, training, and a call-for-help route.

Suggested answer: C. Roles, training, and a call-for-help route address ability and responsibility as well as good intentions.

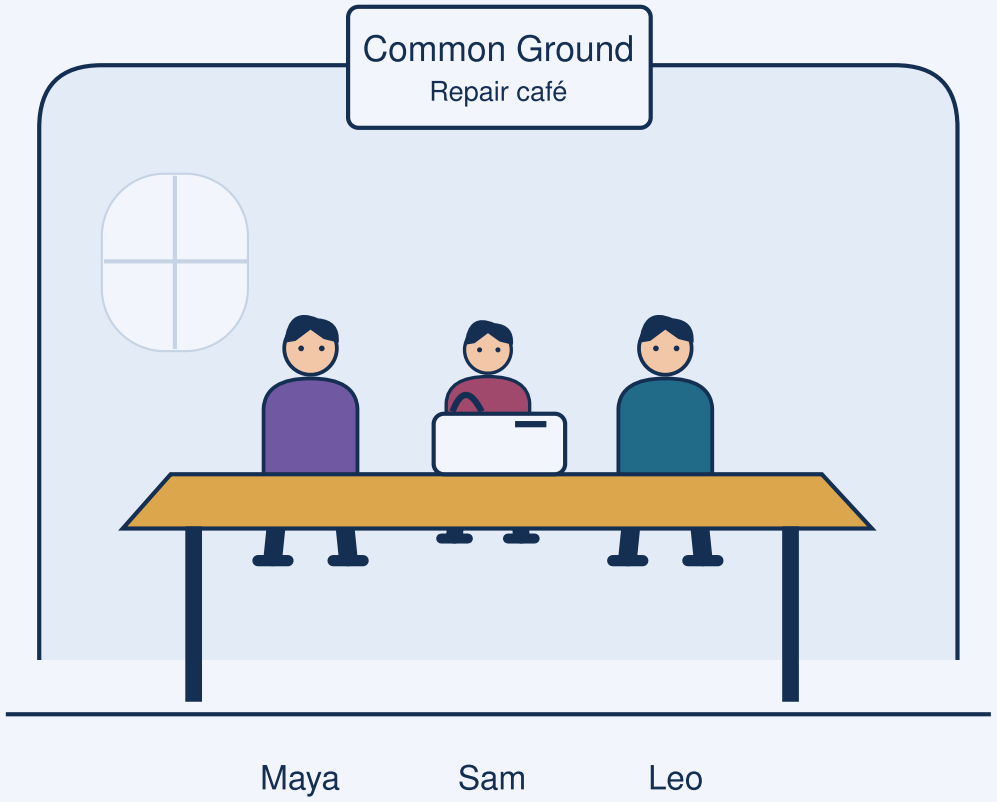
Close your notes. Explain it.

> Distinguish diffusion of responsibility from pluralistic ignorance.

> Use two ideas from earlier chapters to improve an incident review.

1. Diffusion of responsibility concerns who should act. Pluralistic ignorance concerns how people interpret others' reactions.

2. For an incident review, separate observations from blame, compare possible causes, invite independent accounts, or assign clear roles. These draw on chapters one, two, five, and seven.

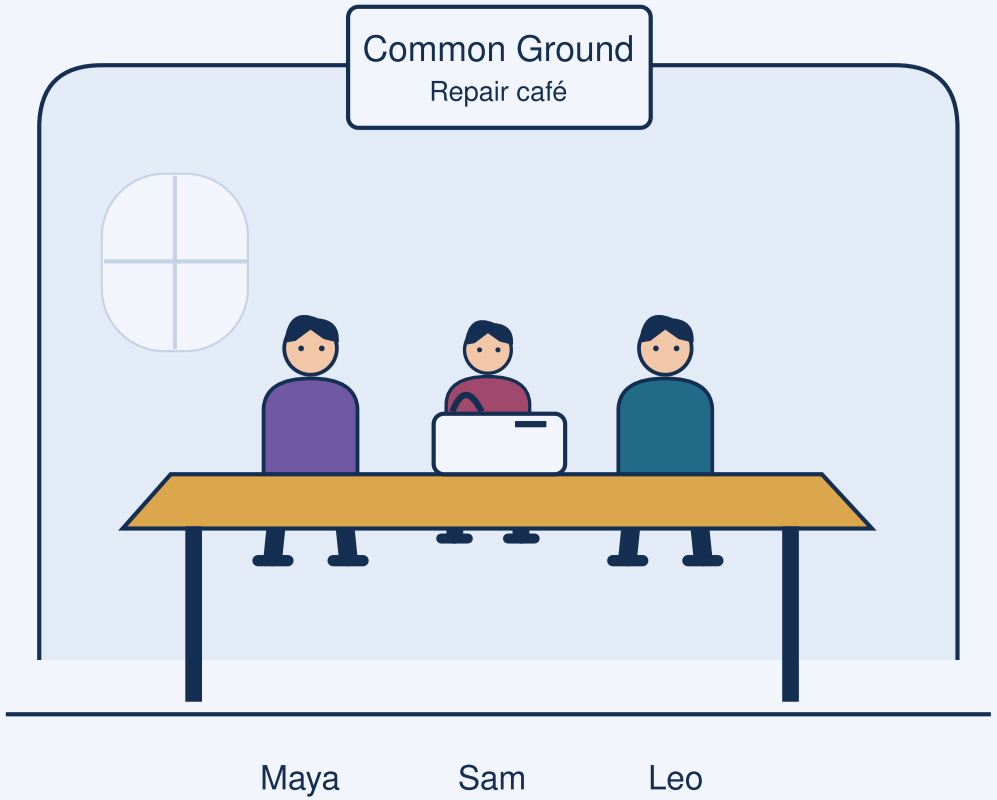


Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Design a helping plan for a low-risk shared task: signal, named role, safe action, and feedback. Explain how context, evidence, influence, and group structure shape your plan.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.